

Venetian cuisine caters to tourists

By Kaya Equevilley

The island city of Venice caters to a global audience of tourists. In response to an increase in tourists the culinary scene is adapting their menu and hours of operation.

Around 30 million tourists each year come to Venice. However, there are only about 50,000 residents living across the some 100 islands connected by bridges in Northern Italy.

Venice has long been a melting pot of cultures, visitors and history. As the city has changed to respond to tourist demand, the culinary scene is adapting, updating everything from recipes to hours of operation. Many Venetians will point you to the seafood-infused Italian food as an example of such a mixture.

Venice experienced an overall decline of 5.4% in the number of restaurants and bars following the pandemic, according to a report by the Statista Research Department.

To combat declines, restaurants turn to other means of advertising their food, said Venice restaurant owners.

“When you open a guidebook it tells you where to go, but is that Venetian food? I don’t know,” said Stefan Parkins, a tourist from the United Kingdom who has visited Venice 5 times in the past 3 years.

Parkins said he usually only stays for a couple of days when he passes through after skiing trips. He, like a number of tourists, said he thought of the food in Venice as expensive and as including fish.

“I like food [in general], but if I’m honest, I don’t know what [Venetian food] is,” said Parkins.

In Venice, restaurants have a lot of similar menus throughout the city.

“All the restaurants serve the same food so it’s hard to tell what is traditional,” said Randy Corley, a tourist from Los Angeles.

Josue Marroquin, a tourist from Texas, described venetian food as “pasta and pizza.”

Corley said he noticed Venetian restaurants are heavy on the seafood, expecting multiple dishes in one meal, and slow when compared to the United States.

This is Corley's first time visiting Venice, he plans to stay for eight days.

Marroquin is in Venice for the first time on a day trip.

"In Sicily [the food] is better," said Matteo, a member of the Italian Special Forces.

Matteo said because he's a member of the Italian Military he was not permitted to speak to the press and asked that his last name not be included.

Matteo said he had lived in Venice for four years as part of a 10 year tour here. He said that the main food in Venice is fish and porchetta di testa, except during carnival then there are frittelles.

"[In Venice,] nothing changes from original traditional cooking I think," said Vianello.

Alberto Vianello is a Venetian who owns Curoe Veneziano restaurant with his three brothers in central Venice.

Vianello and his brothers grew up in Malcontenta, a town on the mainland coast of Venice.

Vianello said that it isn't the traditional cooking that changes so much as how business owners present their restaurant. He feels that more businesses try to attract tourists rather than locals.

"With the internet, restaurant owners became more aware of reviews," said Vianello.

Giovanne Mozzato was raised in Venice Mozzato said you find a lot of the same things in most of the restaurants in Venice. Mozzato owns Chat Qui Rit, a venetian fusion restaurant in Venice.

Chat Qui Rit means "laughing cat" in French. The bistro opened in 1948. It has gone through a number of owners, until Mozzato turned it into a bistro. He, like the previous owners, kept the name, and earned a mention in the Michelin restaurant guide to the city.

Mozzato said he wanted to bring a modern twist to traditional Venetian food.

"It is keeping the ancient roots, but in a new style and taste," he said. "I wanted more of a challenge."

Some said there's more fast food today in Venice than there was even a decade ago.

"People don't take the time to eat, they want to be in and out," said Igor, who is a waiter at Ristorante Antico Martini, and lived in Venice for 15 years.

Some 15 years ago, Igor said restaurants were only open from 12 p.m. to 2 p.m. for lunch, but now many are open all day long.

In many tourist locations you will find restaurants open all day, compared to more rural areas as Venice guide books explain.

More traditional restaurants will be open in the morning at around 8 a.m. until about 2 p.m. then break for siesta time and return again in the evening for dinner, 4 p.m. to about 10:30 p.m.

“People come [to Venice] for a day, and their time zones and schedules are different [when it comes to eating food],” Igor said.